Haligric Research Integration Series

Tenrikyo

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Joyous Life, the Eight Dusts, and the Farmwife Who Became the Shrine of God

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In October 1838, in a farmhouse in Yamato Province, a forty-year-old woman fell into a trance during a healing rite and did not come out of it for three days.

The voice speaking through her asked for something no family would willingly give: the woman herself, handed over as the dwelling place of God.

Her husband said yes. What followed was fifty years of poverty, police raids, midwifery, poetry and dance, and a religion with one of the gentlest ideas about human failure ever put into scripture.

You were not born in sin. You have dust on you. It can be swept.

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Introduction — A God Who Wanted Company

Tenrikyo, usually translated as the Teaching of Divine Reason, is a Japanese religion founded by a woman named Nakayama Miki, whom followers call Oyasama, the Beloved Parent. It dates its beginning to October 26, 1838 on the lunar calendar. It is older than most of the movements usually grouped under the label of Japan's new religions, and it remains one of the rare cases of a sizable religion with a woman as its founder and its central revelatory voice.

The religion's starting premise is unusual. God did not create human beings to worship, to obey, or to be tested. God created them out of a wish to see them live joyfully, and to share in that joy. The goal is called the Joyous Life, and it is meant to be lived here, in this world, among other people, rather than earned in a heaven somewhere else. Tenrikyo has no doctrine of original sin. Its central image for what goes wrong in a human life is domestic and almost cheerful: dust. Selfish uses of the mind settle on an originally clear heart the way dust settles on a shelf, and a person can sweep it away.

The tradition's other striking claim is geographic. Tenrikyo holds that it knows the exact spot on earth where humanity was conceived. That spot, the Jiba, sits inside the main sanctuary in Tenri, Nara Prefecture, the only city in Japan named after a religious organization. Followers visiting it are not said to go on pilgrimage. They are said to return home, and the town's greeting to them is welcome home.

This document was commissioned after the tradition surfaced in a video survey of world religions, and it stands alone in this library because no earlier document covers it. It treats Tenrikyo the way this series treats every tradition: taking its own account seriously, keeping history separate from revelation, and giving its difficulties the same attention as its beauty.

Origins — The Girl Who Wanted to Be a Nun

Maegawa Miki was born on the eighteenth day of the fourth lunar month of 1798, June 2 on the modern calendar, in Sanmaiden Village in Yamato Province, today part of Tenri. Her father, Maegawa Hanshichi, was a village headman of samurai-like status without a stipend. The family were Pure Land Buddhists, and that fact matters. By about twelve or thirteen, the girl could recite sutras and Pure Land hymns from memory and wanted to become a nun.

She was instead married to Nakayama Zenbei, her aunt's son, in the autumn of 1810, when she was about twelve by Western reckoning. She agreed on the condition that she could continue her Buddhist devotions. In 1813 her in-laws placed her in charge of the household, which she ran with a reputation for diligence and for kindness to servants, the poor, and other women's infants. In the spring of 1816 she completed the Fivefold Transmission at Zenpuku Temple, taking a vow to repeat the nenbutsu for life.

None of this looks like the opening of a new religion. It looks like the life of a devout, capable Japanese farm wife in the late Edo period. The revelation would arrive inside that life and turn it inside out, and the Pure Land devotion of her girlhood, with its total reliance on a compassionate power beyond the self, is worth keeping in mind as background for what came next.

The Three Days of October 1838

Miki's eldest son, Shuji, had been suffering a painful leg ailment since 1837, and the family had repeatedly called on a shugenja, a mountain ascetic, named Ichibei to perform incantations. In October 1838 Miki and Zenbei also fell into sudden pain. Ichibei was called once more. His usual medium, a woman named Soyo, was unavailable, so Miki herself took the medium's seat for the rite, called yosekaji.

Tenrikyo tradition holds that what entered her was not the expected Buddhist presence. A voice identified itself as the God of Origin and the God in Truth, and declared that it had descended to save all humankind, and that it wanted Miki as its shrine. The family refused. The trance deepened. Over three days the refusals and the demand continued, until on October 26, 1838, with Miki's condition worsening, Zenbei accepted on the family's behalf. The trance ended. Tenrikyo counts that moment as its founding, and the phrase for what happened is that Miki was settled as the Shrine of Tsukihi, the Moon and Sun.

The surviving accounts of the revelation's exact wording differ from one another, as a historically honest telling should note. Its place in doctrine does not depend on the wording. Tenrikyo teaches that this date was the Promised Time, the moment when 900,099,999 years had passed since humanity's conception, and that the soul and the place had been prepared in advance.

Fifty Years — Poverty, Childbirth, and the Police

After the revelation, Miki spent about three years largely secluded in a storehouse. Then, through the 1840s, she began giving things away: first her own belongings, then the Nakayama family's. She asked her husband to dismantle the main house, starting with the roof tiles, and the work was finished in 1853, the year Zenbei died. The family that had been among the most comfortable in the village fell into real poverty. In Tenrikyo's telling this was the necessary descent to the lowest place, from which the teaching could reach everyone. From the family's position, it was also a hardship they did not choose, and later followers have not hidden that.

In 1853 her youngest daughter, Kokan, went to Naniwa, present-day Osaka, to chant the divine name in the streets, the first missionary act in the religion's history. She was seventeen. Tenrikyo still names this work nioigake, sprinkling the fragrance, and it counts plain speech about the faith, community service, and a cheerful honest life at work as ways of doing it. Then in 1854 came the practice that first brought people to Miki's door: the Grant for Safe Childbirth, obiya-yurushi. Beginning with her daughter Oharu, Miki stroked and breathed on an expectant mother's abdomen three times, assuring her of an easy delivery and releasing her from burdensome postnatal customs. Word spread among women. The early growth of Tenrikyo was carried in significant part by women's experience of birth, a detail that sets it apart from most religious origin stories.

A carpenter named Iburi Izo came to her after his wife's illness and became her closest disciple. In 1864 he built the first house of worship, the Place for the Service. Followers began forming confraternities. Trouble followed quickly. In 1866 yamabushi monks disturbed the residence and complained to the magistrate. Authorization obtained in 1867 lapsed in 1870. Through the 1870s and 1880s local authorities and established religious groups pressed in, and Miki, by then in her eighties, was arrested and detained a number of times for leading an unauthorized religious group. In 1882 police confiscated the two completed tiers of the stone Kanrodai to stop the Service.

She kept teaching. On February 18, 1887 by the modern calendar, the twenty-sixth day of the first lunar month, Miki died around two in the afternoon after followers performed the Service openly, despite the risk of arrest. She was eighty-eight. Tenrikyo was said to have about thirty thousand followers. More than ten thousand people attended her funeral. Tenrikyo does not describe her as dead in the ordinary sense. It teaches that she withdrew from physical view and continues to live and work at her residence, which is still maintained for her with daily meals and a prepared bath.

The Divine Model — Following Her Path

Tenrikyo calls Miki's fifty years after the revelation the Hinagata, the Divine Model. The word means something like a pattern or template, and it answers a question most religions leave vague: what does a life lived by this teaching look like? In the church's telling, God's command to her was to fall to the depths of poverty, and she obeyed despite scorn. She

shared what little food the household had with anyone in need, and she told her hungry children to be grateful even for plain water.

Its most memorable details concern her arrests. She is remembered as having gone to jail without bitterness, thanking the police who took her, and telling those she left behind that she was going out, or going to work. For followers, the Hinagata is the practical standard: to bear hardship with gratitude and cheer, to serve generously, and to meet persecution with no resentment. It is also the reason a follower in trouble might ask what Oyasama would do, and the reason her followers came to feel they had failed her when fear kept them from performing the Service in her final years.

Key Figures and Texts

Three scriptures carry the tradition. The Ofudesaki, or Tip of the Writing Brush, is the most important: seventeen parts and 1,711 verses of waka poetry, written by Miki between 1869 and 1882, covering creation, the Service, the Kanrodai, and God's intention for humankind. She wrote it mostly in simple hiragana in her own Yamato dialect, using only 49 distinct kanji, so that a farmer could read it. It circulated by hand until it was printed in 1928. Police tried to confiscate the manuscripts for destruction in 1883, and they survived anyway. Copies were recalled from churches in 1939 under state pressure, and it could not be preached until the war ended. The Mikagura-uta, the Songs for the Service, is the sung text of the liturgy, for which Miki also composed the melodies and taught the dance. It has five sections, taught between 1866 and 1875. Section Five, the Twelve Songs of 1867, is a counting song, and one Tenrikyo scholar's summary of its themes moves from harvest and the joy of faith through sowing, the mind, and hinokishin to the beginning of spiritual construction. The Osashizu, the Divine Directions, records roughly twenty thousand oral revelations delivered through Iburi Izo from January 4, 1887 to June 9, 1907, published in seven volumes with a three-volume index.

Around these stand the works every seminary student reads: The Doctrine of Tenrikyo, the official statement of belief, revised and authorized after World War II; The Life of Oyasama, the official biography; and Anecdotes of Oyasama. Outside the canon are the Koki, followers' written notes of creation stories Miki told aloud. She never approved them, and they are not scripture, though they preserve details scholars value. The best known is the Doroumi Koki, 160 waka poems compiled by Yamazawa Ryosuke in 1881. Its myth challenged the State Shinto account, copies were collected and burned, and the church never gave it official status, while the breakaway Honmichi treats it as canon.

Iburi Izo, the carpenter, became the Honseki, the deputy through whom revelation continued after Miki's death, and his death in 1907 ended that office. Institutional leadership passed through the Nakayama family, with the title Shinbashira, or Main Pillar. Nakayama Shinnosuke was the first Shinbashira. Nakayama Shozen, the second, took office as a child, led the religion through war and postwar restoration, and presented its doctrine to an international audience of scholars at Munich in 1957. Nakayama Zenye followed. Nakayama Zenji, the fourth, is the current Shinbashira, and Nakayama Daisuke has been named his successor.

God the Parent — Names and Stages of Revelation

Tenrikyo's scriptures name God differently as the revelation unfolds, and that progression is theology in itself. God first appears as kami, the ordinary Japanese word for a deity. Then God appears as Tsukihi, Moon-Sun, the visible natural pair that gives light and warmth to all people alike. Finally God appears as Oya, Parent. Scholars describe the movement as going from an all-powerful God, to a nourishing God, to an intimate God. The sacred name used in prayer and worship is Tenri-O-no-Mikoto.

The theology is hard to fit into standard categories, and Tenrikyo's own scholars say so. It has a single creator, which sounds monotheistic. But that creator is not described as omnipotent in the classical sense, God's body is said to be the world itself, and the other

divinities named in the tradition are instruments God used. The religion's official description lists four properties: God is the revealed God, the creator, the sustainer and protector, and the savior.

The word Parent carries the decisive weight. If God is the parent of all human beings, then all human beings are literally brothers and sisters, and nationality, status, and even religion are secondary. Suffering cannot be a sentence handed down by a judge. It has to be what a loving parent does to get a child's attention. Nearly everything distinctive in Tenrikyo follows from taking that one metaphor literally.

The Truth of Origin — Creation in the Muddy Ocean

Tenrikyo's creation account, the Truth of Origin, is told in The Doctrine of Tenrikyo and first appears in the Ofudesaki in 1874. In the beginning the world was a muddy ocean, and God found it tasteless. God decided to create human beings in order to see them live the Joyous Life and to share that joy.

Looking through the muddy water, God found a fish and a serpent and drew them forward as models of husband and wife. God gained their consent with a promise: when the years of their conception came around again, they would be returned to the original place and adored by their descendants. God then summoned other creatures from the various directions, including an orc, the older word for a killer whale, from the northwest, and a turtle. After gaining each creature's consent and tasting it to learn its nature, God gave each a sacred name and assigned it a function in the human body and in the world. God consumed the loaches in the muddy ocean and made them the seeds of humankind, and placed the seeds in Izanami-no-Mikoto over three days at the spot that would be the Jiba.

After three years and three months she gave birth. The first children were half an inch tall and grew to three inches before dying and being reborn. The second set reached three and a half inches. The third reached four inches, at which their mother declared they would one day reach five feet, smiled, and died contented. Her children, yearning for her, died and were reborn. Humanity then passed through a long series of rebirths as worms, birds, and other animals, until only a she-monkey remained, who bore ten humans at a time. As people grew, the number born at once fell to two and then to one. Land, sky, sun, and moon took form. Human beings were then taught for six thousand years in wisdom and 3,999 years in letters.

A reader coming from Genesis will notice what is missing: no fall, no disobedience, no expulsion. A reader coming from evolutionary biology may notice a resemblance in the long passage through animal forms, though Tenrikyo's account is a sacred narrative and is not a scientific claim. The story's point is intimacy. Every part of the human being was made by consent, from creatures who agreed, by a God who wanted company.

The Ten Aspects of Complete Providence

The creatures of the creation story become the Juzen-no-Shugo, the ten aspects of God's complete providence, each with a sacred name, a function in the body, and a function in the world. They are not ten separate gods. Tenrikyo treats them as ten ways of naming one parental care. Kunitokotachi-no-Mikoto is the providence of water and heaven, governing the eyes and the fluids of the body and appearing in the world as the moon. Omotari-no-Mikoto is the providence of fire and earth, governing warmth and appearing in the world as the sun. These two together stand for Tsukihi, God the Parent.

Kunisazuchi-no-Mikoto governs the female organ, the skin, and joining of every kind. Tsukiyomi-no-Mikoto governs the male organ, the bones, and support. Kumoyomi-no-Mikoto governs eating, drinking, and elimination, and in the world the rise and fall of moisture. Kashikone-no-Mikoto governs breathing and speaking, and in the world the wind. Taishokuten-no-Mikoto governs the cutting of the child's tie to its mother at birth and the breath of life at death, and cutting in general. Otonobe-no-Mikoto governs drawing the

child out in birth, and pulling forth in general. Izanagi-no-Mikoto is the model of man, the seed. Izanami-no-Mikoto is the model of woman, the seedplot.

The list works as a sacred anatomy, and two features stand out. The names are drawn in large part from Japanese mythology, reassigned here to bodily functions. Taishokuten echoes Taishakuten, the Japanese Buddhist name for Indra. And the sexual and digestive functions of the body sit inside the divine order with no embarrassment. Breath, digestion, the severing of the cord, and the last exhalation are all God's direct work, and each principle is said to operate in pairs, in what Tenrikyo calls two-in-one.

A Thing Lent, A Thing Borrowed

The most practical doctrine in Tenrikyo is kashimono-karimono: the body is a thing lent by God and a thing borrowed by the person. Only the mind belongs to you. You did not build your heartbeat. You do not personally operate your digestion. You have been lent an astonishing device, and the only part of the arrangement you actually control is how you use your heart and mind.

This cuts in two directions. It is a source of gratitude, because every ordinary working function of the body is a gift received fresh each day. It is also a source of responsibility, because the mind is free. Tenrikyo teaches that the mind's original nature is clear and pure, and that there was no fall of humanity. Precisely because the mind is free, it can forget its origin and act against God's intention.

God is said to reflect the state of the mind in the condition of the body. When the mind accords with God's intention, blessings flow freely. When dust accumulates, it obstructs them. Illness and trouble are called tebiki, guidance, and are understood as a parent's attempt to get a child's attention, and never as punishment. This is the idea at the center of Tenrikyo's healing practice, and it is also the point at which a thoughtful reader should pause, which the section on controversies takes up directly.

The Eight Dusts

Tenrikyo does not use the word sin for human wrongdoing. It speaks of hokori, dust, and defines it as mistaken uses of the mind that do not accord with God's intention. A single speck is trivial, which is the whole point of the image. Nobody means to let a house get dirty. Dust settles whether you are watching or not, a little at a time, and a room left alone will eventually be unlivable. It also needs no ceremony to remove, only a broom and regular attention.

The tradition names eight. Oshii, miserliness, is reluctance to let go of what you have. Hoshii, covetousness, is wanting what you do not have. Nikui, hatred, is hostility toward others. Kawai, self-love, is excessive attachment to yourself and your own. Urami, grudge-bearing, is holding on to resentment. Haradachi, anger, is irritation and rage. Yoku, greed, is craving for more. Koman, arrogance, is haughtiness.

What makes the list useful is how ordinary it is. None of the eight is a dramatic crime. They are the small daily weather of a human mind, and most people could point to two or three that visited them before lunch. An anthropologist who spent fifteen months with Tenrikyo followers in Kathmandu, Marilena Frisone, describes dust as the thing that stands between a person and their own pure heart, removed both by ethical conduct and by the physical gestures of a sacred dance. In other words, in Tenrikyo the sweeping is literally performed with the hands.

The daily Service makes the metaphor physical. Its opening words, Ashiki o harote tasuke tamae, Tenri-O-no-Mikoto, ask God to sweep away the evils and save us, and the accompanying hand gesture is a sweeping motion, repeated twenty-one times, every morning and evening of a devout person's life.

Causality, Tanno, and Rebirth

Innen, causality, is Tenrikyo's relative of karma, and it is expressed in a farmer's phrase: every seed sown will sprout. What you plant with your intentions and actions comes up later, sometimes in this life and sometimes in another. It differs from the Indian models in its direction. It does not promise escape from rebirth, because the goal is not to get out. The goal is to come back and do it joyfully. Original causality, moto no innen, is the reason for everything: God made human beings to live the Joyous Life. Individual causality is what stands in the way, and it can be changed.

Death is called denaoshi, a making-over or fresh start. The soul returns the borrowed body to God, as a person changes old clothes for new, and later receives another. The mind ceases at death and memory does not carry over, but the soul keeps its causality. Each life is another chance at the Joyous Life in this world, and there is no heaven or hell in the ordinary sense for it to be weighed against.

Tanno is the emotional discipline that goes with all this. It is usually translated as joyous acceptance, and Tenrikyo teachers take pains to say it is not resignation. It is an active, settled refusal to be thrown by events: recognizing a parent's love inside a hard circumstance and deciding to live cheerfully anyway. Shozen Nakayama's 1957 address described hardship as something to meet with gratitude. Whatever a reader believes about the metaphysics, tanno is a recognizable and demanding psychological practice.

The Jiba and the Kanrodai

On June 29, 1875, around noon, Miki identified the exact spot where humanity had been conceived. According to the tradition's account, she walked the yard of the residence until her feet stuck to the ground, and blindfolded followers walking the same yard stopped at the same place. The act is called jiba-sadame, determining the Jiba. That spot is the center of Tenrikyo's world, and the main sanctuary at Church Headquarters is built around it, open on all four sides so that worshippers face it from every direction.

The Jiba is marked by the Kanrodai, the Stand for the Sweet Dew, a hexagonal pillar. Miki taught that the true Kanrodai should be stone, and the belief is that once human hearts are sufficiently purified through the Service, sweet dew will fall from heaven onto a vessel at its top, and that those who receive it will enjoy long life. Its history records the religion's own struggle. Iburi Izo made a wooden version about two meters tall in 1873, installed in 1875. Work on a stone version began in 1881, and only two tiers were finished before police confiscated them in 1882. For a time a pile of pebbles marked the holiest place in the religion. A two-tier wooden stand was placed in 1888. A thirteen-tier wooden model about 2.5 meters tall was installed in 1934, and it is replaced periodically, most recently reported in July 2000. It is forbidden to photograph it.

Everything in the current structure is therefore described as a model. The real Kanrodai remains unbuilt, a promise waiting on the condition of human hearts, which gives the tradition's sacred center an unusual quality. It marks the past exactly and points to a future that has not yet come.

The Kagura Service — Step by Step

The Kagura Service is Tenrikyo's most sacred rite, and it can be performed in only one place: around the Kanrodai at the Jiba. Its purpose is the salvation of all humanity and the building of a Joyous Life world. The Ofudesaki teaches that when it is performed sincerely and without error, God's blessings follow.

Step one: ten performers, five men and five women, take positions around the Kanrodai, each representing one of the ten aspects of providence. The Shinbashira and his wife represent Kunitokotachi and Omotari. Performers are drawn from Headquarters staff, and the roles rotate from month to month. Church teaching says each dancer should become

one with God's mind, the way the instruments of creation did. Oyasama herself named individuals for these positions and warned that using the mind against God's intention in such a role carried consequences.

Step two: each dancer wears a distinctive kagura mask carved in wood. Some are lion-like, others resemble goblins, orcs, or human faces, and some have tails or figures attached, recalling the creatures in the creation story.

Step three: the nine instruments begin. Six are played by men: the flute, the chanpon cymbals, the hyoshigi clappers, the taiko drum, the surigane gong, and the kotsuzumi hand drum. Three are played by women: the koto, the shamisen, and the kokyu fiddle. Singers carry the Mikagura-uta.

Step four: the dancers perform Section One twenty-one times, in seven sets of three. Section Two is performed once. Section Three is performed twenty-one times, again in seven sets of three. Each providence has its own hand movements, so the ten dancers together enact God's work in creating humankind and the world, around the very place where it is said to have happened.

Step five: at Headquarters the Kagura Service is followed by the Teodori, the sacred hand dance, described in the next section. The rite is held on the twenty-sixth of every month. The two grand services fall on January 26, the date of Oyasama's withdrawal from physical life, and on October 26, the date of the founding.

The Daily and Monthly Services — Step by Step

Away from the Jiba, ordinary Tenrikyo practice follows a graded set of services, and the daily one can be done by anyone, anywhere, facing the direction of the Jiba. The morning and evening service, otsutome, is performed twice a day, with the time adjusted to sunrise and sunset.

Ordinary prayer at any church is simple, and it differs from Shinto custom in the number of claps. Sit down, clap four times, bow your head to give thanks and pray, raise your head, and clap four more times. At a regional church, a visitor worships in order toward God the Parent, Oyasama, and the Mitama-sama, the spirits of the deceased, before greeting anyone. The Main Sanctuary at the Jiba is open twenty-four hours.

For the service itself, step one: worshippers pay respects together to God the Parent, thanking God for the day, with the clapper player leading. Step two: seated, the worshippers perform the sung service with hand gestures. In a church, four instruments keep time: the surigane, the chanpon, the hyoshigi, and the taiko, with a small counter called the kazutori tracking the repetitions. At home it is often done with wooden clappers or with no instrument at all. Step three: Section One is performed twenty-one times, the sweeping gesture repeated over and over, then Section Two once, and Section Three nine times, in three sets of three. Step four: worshippers pay respects together to Oyasama and the Mitama-sama. Some churches then practice the dance, read from the Ofudesaki, or hear a short talk. The stated purpose is to sweep away the eight dusts, and devout followers treat it as daily hygiene for the mind.

The Monthly Service, or tsukinamisai, is the central liturgy of every church, held on a date each church sets for itself, such as the third Sunday. It has two parts. First comes the Seated Service, in which six people, three men and three women, sit in a line facing the shrine and perform the same text as the Kagura Service, with the third section done nine times, in three sets of three. Next comes the Teodori, in which six dancers, three men on the left and three women on the right, stand in one line and perform identical movements in unison through the Eight Verses of the Yorozuyo and the Twelve Songs, with the full complement of instruments and one or two singers. A North American church describes the order this way: opening prayers, the Seated Service, Songs 1 to 12, a sermon, a personal Sazuke session for healing prayer, and announcements, taking about two hours. Morning and evening services there last about twenty minutes.

The year at Church Headquarters turns on these dates. New Year's Day Service is at 5:00 a.m. on January 1. The Spring Grand Service, on January 26, honors Oyasama's withdrawal from physical life, and the Autumn Grand Service, on October 26, marks the founding of the teaching. Monthly Service falls on the 26th of every other month. Oyasama's birthday is celebrated on April 18. Memorial services for the dead fall on March 27 and September 27, and regional churches take assigned dates in those months. Two rarer services complete the calendar: the Service for Germination, around April 16, prays for rice and harvest, and the Service for Safe Childbirth is held at night on selected dates. At the Jiba these major services use the Kagura Service, while regional churches hold a Seated Service followed by the dance.

This is an uncommon feature of world religion. The core liturgy is a dance, composed by the founder, performed with the body, and performed equally by men and women.

The Sazuke — Step by Step

The Sazuke, the Divine Grant, is Tenrikyo's healing prayer. It descends from the grants Miki herself gave her followers, and it is the means by which ordinary people carry on her work.

Step one: anyone seventeen or older applies through their church and hears the Besseki at the Jiba, nine lectures that each cover the same truth so nothing is missed. The pace is normally one a month, though those returning from overseas can finish all nine in one visit with rest days between. Each lecture opens with the Besseki Pledge and is followed by reflection and practice. The attendance slip must be kept, because losing it without records means starting again. Step two: after the ninth lecture, having resolved to help save others, the person requests the Sazuke. Step three: it is granted through the Shinbashira at Headquarters. The recipient becomes a yoboku, a useful timber, using the carpenter's language that runs throughout Tenrikyo for building the Joyous Life.

Step four: from then on, the yoboku can administer the Sazuke to anyone who is ill or suffering, member or not, through a prayer with hand movements and bodily contact. Tenrikyo says it can be given no other way. Missionaries offer it to many people who are not members. Step five: the giver and receiver both participate. The church is emphatic that the Sazuke is not a magic spell. It requires the giver's sincere wish to see someone saved and the recipient's trust in God the Parent, and when the two come together, blessings follow.

Tenrikyo's own teaching says the Sazuke can change the heart even when no visible physical healing occurs, and that is what it counts as the deeper result. Since the giver's body is itself lent by God, the act is understood as one borrowed body reaching toward another on God's behalf. The church also explicitly accepts modern medicine. It teaches that doctors and medicine are God's gift, begun for what the Ofudesaki calls weeding and fertilizing, and it holds that the Service and Sazuke cleanse the mind and do not compete with treatment. An Osashizu of July 7, 1890, says directly that doctors and medicine are not to be refused. The Tenri Yorozu-sodansho Foundation, set up in 1935, was built on this combination, and its Ikoi-no-Ie Hospital, opened in Tenri in 1966 with 900 beds, has three departments side by side: Medical Treatment, Religious Guidance, and Service. So the Sazuke is offered alongside medical care and is not presented as a replacement for it. Abroad it travels well. Yueh-po Huang's 2017 study of Taiwan found the Sazuke central to Tenrikyo's growth there, because it resembles Taiwanese folk therapy and fits a society that already mixes several kinds of medicine, and it helped followers cope with everyday hardship.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Tenrikyo's daily practice is built from very simple parts. Twice a day a person sweeps the mind with the Service. Throughout the day a person watches for the eight dusts. And a person practices hinokishin, which is the tradition's answer to almost every problem.

Hinokishin means daily offering, a voluntary act done out of gratitude for the borrowed body. The church traces its first recorded instance to the 1864 construction of the Place for the Service, when followers gave their labor. It is explicitly not done for pay or recognition, and the classic forms are humble: cleaning public toilets, sweeping parks, weeding, picking up litter. The work other people least want to do is considered the most sincere. The logic reverses ordinary self-care. When you feel low, you do not go inward to rest. You use the body you have been lent to do something helpful for someone, because that is what bodies are for, and the gratitude that comes from doing it is the cure. Tenrikyo The Women's Association, founded on January 28, 1910, grew from monthly study and dance meetings started around 1895 by Tamae Nakayama, wife of the first Shinbashira. It holds its convention on April 19 and runs the Tenri Day Care Center so parents can attend courses. The Children's Pilgrimage to Jiba fills the city each summer with parades, fireworks, and attractions, and in 2017 it drew 231,012 children and leaders over ten days from Japan and 20 other countries and regions. Hinokishin Day brings this out in public: a church report from around 2005 described about 2,400 locations across Japan, with followers cleaning stations, kindergartens, and civic centers, and members overseas giving blood or collecting litter. The same impulse is organized at scale through the Disaster Relief Hinokishin Corps, which grew from relief work after the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake and from a drive beginning in 1969 to establish a corps in every diocese. After the 2024 Noto Peninsula Earthquake, the Ishikawa corps began water supply support on January 5. After the 2011 earthquake and tsunami, the church reported more than 5,000 corps members working in Iwate, Miyagi, and Fukushima by that April. In the autumn of 2024, after floods struck a Noto Peninsula already recovering from that year's earthquake, 451 members worked in Wajima and removed about 333 tons of debris and mud from 28 homes.

The practice of tanno operates as an emotional regulation skill. When something bad happens, the instruction is to look for the parent's intention inside it and to choose cheerfulness as an act of will. The term yokigurashi, Joyous Life, is applied to ordinary housework, childrearing, and work. It offers no retreat from family life, no celibate class, and no required dietary rule. The ideal is a person at home in the middle of life, in a good mood, helping.

Followers also point to the mind-body link in practical ways, asking what a given ailment may be saying about the state of their heart. A caution is needed here, because that habit can be comforting in one person and damaging in another. Used as a spur to reflection and kindness, it can give hardship meaning. Used as a way of blaming a sick person for their illness, it causes harm, and Tenrikyo's own teaching that suffering is not punishment is the correction for that misuse.

The Grant of Safe Childbirth — Step by Step

The practice that first brought women to Miki's door still exists, and in a form anyone can follow. Step one: a woman at least six months pregnant applies through her church. Step two: the application goes to the church that supervises hers. Step three: she returns to the Jiba to receive the Grant, or her husband or a parent may go for her. Step four: she receives three packets of sacred rice, blessed through the Service for Safe Childbirth at the Jiba.

Step five: the packets are taken at specific moments. The first, for safe carrying, is taken at home with a prayer that the baby stay in a good position and go to full term. The second, for quickness, is taken when labor begins, with a prayer for a safe delivery. The third, for purification and settling, is taken after the birth with thanks and a prayer for recovery. This is offered as a spiritual support for pregnancy, alongside normal prenatal and medical care, which it does not replace.

A Tenrikyo Wedding — Step by Step

Weddings are held before God the Parent and Oyasama. The church's own account of the wedding of successor-designate Daisuke Nakayama gives the order at Church

Headquarters. Step one: the couple, families, and Service performers walk to the Main Sanctuary and worship. Step two: they move to the Foundress' Sanctuary, where everyone pays respects to Oyasama, clapping in unison with the Shinbashira. Step three: the couple exchange sake on the middle dais. Step four: the chief officiant reads the couple's pledge and prays with them, and the Shinbashira leads everyone in prayer. Step five: the party performs a thanksgiving service in the Main Sanctuary. Step six: they pay respects at the Foundress' Sanctuary and the Memorial Hall, and the ceremony ends, about an hour after it began.

Passing Away for Rebirth — The Funeral, Step by Step

Tenrikyo calls death denaoshi, passing away for rebirth. The body is returned to God the Parent, the soul borrows a new one, and the dead are memorialized in gratitude. The church stresses that this is not worship of ancestor spirits, because faith stays directed to God the Parent and Oyasama.

The fullest public record of the rites is the church's account of the funeral of the third Shinbashira, Nakayama Zenye, who died on June 24, 2014, at 81. This was a leader's funeral, far larger than a follower's, but it shows the order. Step one: the transfer of the soul, held in the evening. The chief officiant read the prayer for the transfer, the lights were turned off, and the transfer was performed to gagaku music. Step two: food offerings were placed on the altar and a prayer for settling the soul was read, and the family offered sacred branches. About 4,700 people attended. Step three: a farewell the next day, when the family said their last goodbyes and the coffin left in a cortege past lines of followers.

Step four: the funeral itself, on July 6, for more than 20,000 people. The photograph and urn were carried to the altar to gagaku while the crowd stood in silence. Officiants entered, food was offered, a prayer was given, and the chief officiant read the farewell prayer. Step five: branch offerings by the family, guests, and everyone present, followed by messages, a eulogy, and words of thanks. Step six: interment at the Toyoda-sansha columbarium, with an enshrinement ceremony at the Memorial Hall about a month later. Memorial services then continue at intervals. The branch offering is the very element the church has been removing, as described below: in February 2024 tamagushi was taken out of funerals.

Returning to the Jiba

Tenrikyo does not speak of pilgrimage. Going to Tenri is called ojiba-gaeri, returning to the Jiba, because every human being was conceived there and is therefore simply coming back to the family home. Hotels, dormitories, and residents greet arrivals with okaeri nasai, welcome home, and followers stay in large dormitories called tsumesho, which were built from 1896 onward and still occupy much of the city.

The town's rhythm follows the calendar of the Service. Crowds peak on the twenty-sixth of each month and at the great anniversaries. Oyasama's birthday on April 18 is a major celebration: a report from around 2009 described about 80,000 people gathering, with a meal offered to her at the Foundress' Sanctuary and thousands singing in a joyous chorus. The complex also holds the Memorial Hall, with altars for the Nakayama family and early disciples, for those who performed the Service, and for ministers and followers. Followers volunteer in the kitchens, hallways, and grounds as hinokishin. Those who wish to deepen their faith enroll in the three-month Shuyoka course, which is offered in several languages and studies the core texts and the Service.

The most recent great occasion was the 140th Anniversary of Oyasama on January 26, 2026, the culmination of a three-year preparatory campaign described in Tenrikyo's traditional phrase as three years, one thousand days. In his New Year's greeting for 2026, which the church dates as Tenrikyo year 189, Shinbashira Zenji Nakayama asked members to carry their efforts through to that day. About 120,000 people came despite a severe cold wave, including about 1,300 pilgrims from 22 countries and regions. Successor-designate Daisuke Nakayama served as chief officiant, the Kagura Service and the dance were

performed, and at 2:00 p.m. the crowd clapped together at the sound of a siren to mark a new beginning. The Shinbashira warned that returning to ordinary times should not mean returning to how things were.

Surviving the State — Compromise and Restoration

Tenrikyo spent its first century negotiating with a Japanese state that did not want it. In 1880 followers inaugurated a legal front at a Shingon temple, complete with a Buddhist fire rite, because they had no other way to gather. Petitions for recognition were denied in 1884 and 1885. In 1888, after Miki's death, the Tokyo governor approved Tenrikyo Church Headquarters as a lowest-class church under the Shinto Main Bureau.

Then the pressure increased. On April 6, 1896, the Home Ministry issued Directive No. 12 ordering surveillance of the movement. The Service was changed, its masks and full form were curtailed, and the deity's name was altered to Tenri-no-Okami. Tenrikyo presented itself as a Shinto sect. After a long campaign, its fifth petition for independence was accepted on November 27, 1908, and it took its place among the Sect Shinto organizations, a status it held until the end of the war. In that period it also became the first Japanese new religion to do organized social work, opening an orphanage, a public nursery, and a school for the blind.

The Ofudesaki was published in 1928 and the Osashizu completed in 1931. The Kagura Service, prohibited since 1896, returned in 1934. On December 16, 1935, about four hundred police investigated Headquarters on suspicion of tax evasion, part of a decade in which the Japanese state crushed Omoto and Honmichi outright. Tenrikyo survived by bending. In 1939 Shozen Nakayama announced Instruction Eight, which reformed doctrine and ritual to fit state requirements.

On August 15, 1945, the day Japan announced its surrender, Shozen announced the restoration of the teaching. The Mikagura-uta was reissued in 1946, the Ofudesaki in 1948, and the Osashizu and a revised Doctrine in 1949. In 1966 the official newspaper Tenri Jiho declared that Tenrikyo is nothing but Tenrikyo, and in 1970 the church left the Sect Shinto Union. Scholar Masato Kato, writing in 2023, describes this as de-Shintoization, a selective process that was still under way decades later. Himorogi were dropped in 1976, and shimenawa and tamagushi offerings left the monthly service by 1986. Tamagushi offerings were removed from funerals only in February 2024, while shrine-style altars, gagaku music, and norito-like liturgy remain. So the visible Shinto look of a Tenrikyo church is partly inheritance and partly a question still being worked through.

Tenri City — A Religious Town and Its Future

Tenri, in Nara Prefecture, was formed on April 1, 1954, from the merger of three towns and three villages, and it is the only city in Japan named after a religious organization. Scholar Erica Baffelli traced how followers' relocation reshaped the place long before that. The hamlet of Mishima grew from 358 people in 1882 to 2,214 by 1913, and a rail line from Nara opened in 1902 to serve pilgrims.

The city holds Tenri University, Tenri Seminary, Tenri Hospital, a set of schools, and the Sankokan Museum, begun in 1930 from Shozen Nakayama's Chinese ethnographic collection and now holding more than 280,000 items. Its longest-running school is Shuyoka, the three-month spiritual development course set up in April 1941. A new session begins every month, students attend sunrise service, classes, dance and instrument practice, and hinokishin, and 644,389 people had completed it by September 2024. The city also has Tenri Central Library, founded in 1926 from a collection that began with the founder's family, which now holds six volumes designated as national treasures of Japan. Welfare work follows the teaching that all people are brothers and sisters. The Tenrikyo Federation for Foster Parents, founded in 1981, was the first religious federation for foster parents in Japan. Tenrikyo also became known for an unexpected reason: its judo program has produced champions. Its largest architectural project is the Oyasato-yakata, a building

complex meant to surround the sanctuary in a square, drawn from a founder's prophecy that the area would expand to eight cho square. Announced in 1953, the plan called for sixty-eight interconnected wings.

Only twenty-five wings, about forty percent, have been completed, and none has been built since 2005. Baffelli attributes the stall to high costs, falling donations, and land negotiations, and judges full completion very unlikely. A 2023 Diamond Online report similarly described a sharp drop in donations to the city. The town's shopping street has seen more vacant shops, and the city has started planning for less dependence on the religion. The building stands as a physical record of postwar optimism meeting the demographics of a shrinking Japan.

Schisms and Offshoots

A religion founded on continuing revelation will have trouble ending revelation, and Tenrikyo's history is full of people who received further messages after the official stream closed. Headquarters regards the resulting groups as heresies, most of which have their own scriptures and reject Tenri's authority.

The earliest schisms happened during Miki's life: Tenrin-O Kyokai in 1865, around the so-called Sukezo Incident, and Tenrin-O Meisei Kyodan in 1881. Daidokyo followed in 1897, and many others after. The most important is Honmichi, founded by Onishi Aijiro, a Tenrikyo missionary who received a revelation in Yamaguchi on July 15, 1913, and declared himself the living Kanrodai. It formally separated in 1925. Because it openly defied the divinity of the Emperor, Honmichi was crushed in 1928 and 1938, and Onishi was sentenced to life imprisonment in 1938. Honmichi itself later split, with Honbushin breaking away in the early 1960s under Onishi Tama.

In Korea, Daehan Cheolligyo emerged after Japan's defeat, conducting ceremonies in Korean, a schism driven by nationalism more than theology. Hachirakukai Kyodan, from 1946, venerates the legendary ruler Himiko. These groups show how portable Miki's ideas were, and how powerful the claim of a direct line to God becomes in the hands of the next inspired person.

Legacy and Influence — Overseas Mission

Tenrikyo began moving overseas in 1893, when missionaries went to the Korean Peninsula. Its first overseas church, Taichu Church, opened in Taiwan on September 12, 1897, and the first in Korea in 1904. A Mission Headquarters in America was established in 1934, followed by Taiwan in the same year, Brazil in 1951, and Hawaii in 1954. Brazil is the instructive case. The first church there, Noroeste, was founded by Kita Grand Church in 1927, and Nankai Grand Church sent ten families in 1929. By January 2007 there were 82 churches, 43 of them led by Japanese immigrants. Masanobu Yamada of Tenri University estimated about 20,000 members in 2010, against about 4,000 in the 2000 census, and found that many non-Japanese Brazilians read Tenrikyo through Christianity and Kardecist Spiritism, a bricolage he says revitalizes the religion. Later centers opened in Nepal in 1966, Paris in 1970, Colombia and Singapore in 1972, New York in 1977, Hong Kong in 1978, Thailand in 1982, Mexico, Indonesia, and the Philippines in 1985, Oceania in 1997, and the United Kingdom in 2000. Marilena Frisone's fifteen months of fieldwork in Kathmandu, published in 2023, found Nepalese followers treating dust as mistaken thought to be removed through ethics and the gestures of the sacred dance.

One of the most striking chapters is in Africa. On September 24, 1960, Shozen Nakayama's delegation landed at Brazzaville, and the Nsonga brothers later converted. On April 26, 1975, Alphonse Nsonga became head minister of the Congo-Brazzaville church, and Tenrikyo's African presence grew from there. A church opened in 1966, the Japanese missionary center closed in 1989, and the church was looted in the 1998 civil war, with several members killed. Midori Horiuchi found that Congolese members, left largely without Japanese missionaries, sing and move in a style shaped by Christian choirs, an

adaptation of their own. Tenrikyo has also held formal dialogues with Christianity in Rome and Tenri.

In Japan, Tenrikyo's numbers have fallen sharply. Figures from Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs give 1,121,541 followers in 2025, down from a peak of 2,298,420 in 1974. Worldwide membership was estimated at over two million in 2002, and more than 16,000 churches operate in Japan. Its broader legacy may be structural. Many of the Japanese new religions that followed share the pattern Miki helped establish: a charismatic healer, a revelation for the whole world, and a promise of happiness in this life.

Controversies and Fairness

Tenrikyo has largely avoided the kind of national scandal that has dogged some other Japanese religious movements, but a search of Japanese-language sources shows real criticism that English-language material mostly leaves out. Those accounts come from a general reference summary, and they are reported here as claims made by the critics named.

The first is the theology of illness, and it has a history. Japanese sources report that in the movement's early period believers were accused of rejecting doctors and medicine, and that some healing practices led to police action, including an 1882 case called the Wazaiji Incident in which a fellow believer died during a healing practice. Teaching that the state of the mind is reflected in the body gives suffering meaning, but it can also lay blame on the sick. Shozen Nakayama's 1957 address describes misfortune as divine guidance urging people to reform, and healing claims in the tradition's literature are asserted from inside faith without independent documentation. In fairness, Tenrikyo insists that suffering is not punishment, and it runs a major hospital and accepts modern medicine. Nobody should delay or refuse medical care on the basis of any teaching described here.

The second concerns the founder's family. Miki's dispossession of the household was a sacred act in the tradition's telling, and an imposition on a husband and children in any other telling. Critics Shimada Hiromi and Hayakawa Kazuhiro go further, claiming that the family's ruin came from her eldest son's losses speculating in rice and cotton futures, and that the church later reframed this and pressed believers for money. These are the critics' claims, and they are not the church's account. Writers including Aoji Shin have also argued that the official biography makes her too passive a vessel. A former minister, Yashima Hideo, was dismissed in 1986 after urging reform and questioning traditional accounts. Historians themselves disagree: Murakami Shigeyoshi's reading of Miki as an anti-state figure has been criticized as politically motivated.

The third concerns gender. A religion founded by a woman, spread by women's experience of childbirth, and uniquely balanced in its liturgy between male and female dancers has been led for its entire institutional history by hereditary male Shinbashira from the Nakayama family, and the Kagura Service's roles remain assigned along lines of family and staff seniority.

The fourth concerns empire and accommodation. Tenrikyo's earliest overseas churches were in Korea and Taiwan during the expansion of Japanese power, and its survival required doctrinal concessions to State Shinto from 1896 to 1945. Speaking at a church-hosted lecture, Professor Lee Won Bum of Dongseo University argued that early missionaries in Korea were focused on faith and that their work was not tied to colonialism, noting that Tenrikyo was the only pre-war Japanese religion to take root in post-war Korea. Akihiro Yamakura of Tenri University takes a middle view, that followers both complied with and kept apart from empire, and adds a cost: followers' remarks on overseas mission drew US intelligence attention, and after Pearl Harbor ministers and followers in America often suffered wartime internment. Lee's is a serious argument, though it was made at the church's own event, and it should be weighed alongside Korean Tenrikyo's nationalist break. Followers remember this as a painful burden carried to protect the faith. Honmichi's members, who refused to bend and were imprisoned for it, remember the same years

differently, and Korean Tenrikyo's break after 1945 is a reminder that mission and empire overlapped. A further split occurred in South Korea in 1985, after a change to a sacred structure's shape meant to ease anti-Japanese feeling. The postwar restoration deserves credit, and so do the honest questions about what came before it.

Numbers are disputed too. Official figures have long been challenged: sociologist Ueda Yoshihiro has argued that the real membership may be closer to 500,000, and many listed churches are said to be nominal, having stopped operating without ever formally closing.

Finally, a note on the creature called the orc in English translations: it is the older word for a killer whale, and has no relation to fantasy fiction. A reader of the Kagura Service's description might otherwise misread it.

The Haligricity Lens

Tenrikyo offers the Haligric practitioner one of the most usable pictures of how the inner life goes wrong. The Tetralty holds that a feeling generates a thought, a thought generates a word, a word generates an action, and that trouble comes when those four fall out of alignment. The eight dusts sit right at the start of that chain. Resentment, wanting, and self-regard settle first as feeling and thought. Left alone, they become speech and conduct. The Service then answers on all four levels at once: a felt gratitude, a turned mind, a sung word, and a moving hand. The sweeping is not symbolic of anything. The practitioner is doing it, physically, twice a day.

The doctrine of the borrowed body has much to say to a tradition that treats the body as sacred. It removes shame from the body's functions, since every one of them is named divine work, and it removes entitlement, since none of them is yours by right. Haligricity would add its own caution: the body is more than a rental unit, and the divine is present in all things, including the sick body. Illness should never be read as a verdict. Tenrikyo's refusal of the word sin is the part of the teaching a Haligric reader can keep without hesitation.

Above all, Tenrikyo offers the idea that joy is the point and that it is a practice. Most traditions in this library ask a person to endure this world for the sake of something better. Miki's God asks only to watch you enjoy being alive, and then hands you a broom. Grand Rising is close kin to that instinct: greet the day upward, on purpose, whatever the day has in it.

Closing

Somewhere in Tenri this morning, before the sun was fully up, a person sat down facing a hexagonal pillar they may never be allowed to photograph, and began moving their hands in a sweeping motion that a farmwife composed a hundred and fifty years ago. The stone Kanrodai still has not been built. The sweet dew has not yet fallen. The dust keeps settling, as it always will, and the broom is still right there.

The promise was never that the house would stay clean. The promise was that you are a beloved child in your parent's home, that nothing on you is permanent, and that the day is still available to be enjoyed. You are the current.